

“ THAT’S ONE SMALL STEP FOR [A] MAN, ONE GIANT LEAP FOR MANKIND. ”

Neil Armstrong, on first setting foot on the Moon, on July 21, 1969

YASSER ARAFAT (1929–2004), A PALESTINIAN FREEDOM FIGHTER, became the leader of the **Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO)** in February. He had formed the radical group **Al-Fatah** in the late 1950s, which was merged with the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP) to form the PLO.

In Libya, **Mu’ammar al-Gaddafi** (b. 1940) led a group of army officers to depose King Idris (1890–1983) on September 1, in a bloodless coup, and established the **Libyan Arab Republic**.

Nigeria banned food aid from the Red Cross to the breakaway state of **Biafra**, bringing millions of people to the brink of **starvation**. Biafra accused Nigeria of using starvation and genocide to win the civil war (1967–70), and pleaded for help from the world.

On August 14, **Britain sent troops into Northern Ireland** following three days of violence in the predominantly Catholic bogside area of **Londonderry**. Although intended to be a brief intervention, the troops remained after the **violence intensified**.

Willy Brandt (1913–92) was sworn in as the **Chancellor of West Germany** on October 21, becoming the first Socialist politician to lead a German government since 1930.

Eagle returns

Apollo 11’s lunar module Eagle, holding astronauts Neil Armstrong and Buzz Aldrin, makes its way back to the command module.



Biafra starves

A child suffers the effects of hunger and malnutrition during the Biafra blockade. Pictures of the famine garnered worldwide sympathy.

Concorde, the supersonic airliner, made its **maiden flight** in March. Piloted by Andre Turcot, the Anglo-French plane took off from **Toulouse** in France; it reached 10,000 ft (3,050 m), and was in the air for 27 minutes.

Elsewhere in Europe, Beatle **John Lennon** (1940–80) and his wife **Yoko Ono** spent **two weeks in bed**, drawing the world’s attention to peace. They spent the first week at the Hilton Amsterdam, in March, and the second at the Queen Elizabeth Hotel in Montreal, where the song *Give Peace a Chance* was recorded, in May.

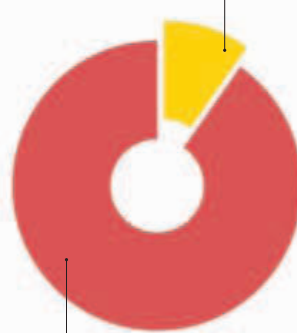
Large-scale **music festivals** were held in Europe and the US during a summer that epitomized the **hippie movement**. The British band The Rolling Stones played a

free concert at Hyde Park, London; the American musician, Bob Dylan (b. 1941), performed the headline act at the **Isle of Wight Festival**, England; and up to 400,000 turned up at **Woodstock**, New York.

Millions marched across the US on October 15 to protest against the **Vietnam War**. In Washington DC, 250,000 people gathered to participate in **antiwar rallies** and hear activists speak.

On July 21, **Neil Armstrong** (b. 1930) and **Edwin Aldrin** (b. 1930) took man’s **first steps on the moon** from their spacecraft *Apollo 11*. Millions watched this televised event that represented a **symbolic victory** for the US over the USSR during the Cold War.

Time spent on the moon:
21 hours, 31 minutes, and
20 seconds



Mission duration
8 days, 3 hours,
18 minutes, and 35 seconds

The lunar mission

The prime mission objective of Apollo 11 was stated simply as: “perform a manned lunar landing and return.”



This photograph shows hijacked planes that were set on fire by Palestinian militants belonging to Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP).

IN CAMBODIA, THE HEAD OF STATE, PRINCE NORODOM SIHANOUK

(b. 1922) was overthrown by **General Lon Nol** in a **coup**, on March 18. Lon Nol claimed to have support from the US. In April, **President Richard Nixon** (1913–94) ordered US troops and B-52 bombers into **Cambodia** to destroy North Vietnamese and Vietcong sanctuaries and supplies.

In early September, **Palestinian militants** forced two planes to fly to the Jordanian desert, where the hijackers **blew up the aircraft** after releasing most of the hostages. A third plane was flown to **Cairo** and was also blown up. After 24 days of talks, the remaining **hostages were freed** in exchange for seven Palestinian prisoners. On September 16, fighting broke out between Jordanian troops and PLO guerrillas. Egyptian President **Gamal Abdel Nasser** (b. 1918) **brokered a settlement** on September 27. **Nasser died** of a heart attack the next day. He had become the most powerful figure in the Middle East while **attempting to unify Arab nations**.

A **catastrophic cyclone** hit East Pakistan (modern Bangladesh) on November 12. The **Bhola Cyclone** was the **deadliest ever recorded**,

with up to 500,000 casualties. Alleging neglect and lack of help from West Pakistan, the Bengalis went on to vote for Sheikh Mujibur Rahman’s **Awami League**, which demanded autonomy from West Pakistan in the following elections (see 1971).

Elections were held in Chile on September 4, and **Salvador Allende’s Marxist coalition** was elected. Allende instituted a program of sweeping **nationalization and reforms**.

In April, the German pharmaceutical company **Grünenthal** pledged to pay DM 100 million to **thalidomide victims**. Thalidomide, a drug given to pregnant women for nausea, was withdrawn in 1961 after nearly 10,000 babies were born with **major disabilities**.

Charles De Gaulle (b. 1890), who led the French resistance to the Nazi occupation during World War II and became the President of liberated France, **died** on November 9. His funeral was held on Armistice Day, November 11.

The Beatles, the most famous music band in the world, split when Paul McCartney (b. 1942) announced his decision to leave in April. The **group officially disbanded** on December 31.

500 THOUSAND THE NUMBER KILLED IN THE CYCLONE IN BANGLADESH

